DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Can a Good God Create Evil?

Daat Tevunot §98-106

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §98-106
Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Monday 27 February 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Everything comes through emanation

The recording picks up as the Ramhal is laying the groundwork for the question of evil. Nothing in existence happens without HaKadosh Barukh Hu giving it emanation, shefa, energy. Everything flows from the first source. As the Rabbi put it, God has no body, so we speak of energy that comes down from Him and brings everything into being. The Rambam explains this at greater length.

A participant asked whether everything passes through the stars and constellations. The Rabbi said no; the Ramhal uses the example of the blade of grass, which the Midrash says has a force above it telling it to grow. That force is a malakh. And what is a malakh? "Just a filter." The energy is too strong to come directly from Hashem, so it passes through chains, and the malakh is simply the messenger that passes it on, reducing it as it goes from level to level. That is why the Rambam speaks of ten levels of angels. Angels are not creatures flying around; they are vehicles through which God's energy is transmitted and filtered down into this world.

Do they have autonomy? Almost never, said the Rabbi. 99.9% of the time a malakh is nothing but a vehicle. The odd stories in the Midrash where angels seem to act on their own were, as discussed in the past, given to teach a lesson.

Nothing comes from God Himself

The next paragraph adds: whatever Hashem does with us, it is never God Himself that we are talking about. He is exalted above everything. What we experience are emanations that He willed in order to create the system of the world. The source is from Hashem, the means by which it reaches you are from Hashem, and the creatures are the result. Hashem created as many kinds of emanation as He wished: one stream of wisdom, another of strength, another of wealth.

§101-102: why so many streams?

The Neshamah asks: why not create one stream that contains everything? Why separate wisdom, strength and wealth?

The Rabbi recalled an analogy he had given before. Light is one light. Put on sunglasses with red filters and you see red; with green filters, green; with yellow, yellow. The source is one, but in order for us to receive it, it must come in different streams, because we are human and we compartmentalise. "Some people are clever, but weak. Some people are strong, but stupid. Some people are wealthy, but mean."

The Sekhel explains (§102) that when he says "emanation", he means it as it reaches us. We cannot speak of how Hashem gives; we can only discuss it from the side of the recipient. We feel a day of wisdom or a day of strength. But at the root it is all one.

The question: where does evil come from?

Now the Ramhal returns to the main topic. There is good in the world and there is bad. Before giving his own answer, the Sekhel asks the Neshamah what she thinks.

The Rabbi put the question to the class: "How can there be any bad in the world when HaKadosh Barukh Hu is the source of all good?" Someone suggested it comes from hester, concealment. The Rabbi pushed back: if He is concealed, there should simply be nothing. So where is the bad coming from?

Another participant tried a fuller answer: an emanation reaches the body and soul together; the soul is what animates the body, which by itself is a lump of meat ("vayipah beapav nishmat hayim"); and depending on how far "the concealment knob" is turned, the result looks good or bad to us. The Rabbi said this was correct to some extent, and the idea of the knob came back strongly in the following classes.

§104-105: the Neshamah's answer is rejected

The Neshamah's answer (§104) is simple: there is a stream of good and there is a stream of bad. What is the difficulty?

The Sekhel (§105) rejects this outright. You cannot say God creates a stream of bad. He is the source of good, and from the source of good there cannot come bad.

But then where does it come from? The Sekhel brings the verse in Yeshayahu: "oseh shalom uvore ra", He makes peace and creates evil. So God does create evil. Why does the verse change its language: "makes" for peace, but "creates" for evil?

§106: makes peace, creates evil

The Sekhel answers: it says "bore ra", creates evil, and not "oseh ra", makes evil. "Bore" here means a step removed. God allowed evil to exist; if He did not want it, it would not be. But He does not actively make the bad.

So there are two kinds of creation. Asiyah, making, is active: God is directly involved in making peace, the good. And then there is the allowing of evil to exist. How that allowing works, through withdrawal, is the subject of the next class.

Summary

- Everything exists through emanation from HaKadosh Barukh Hu, filtered down through malakhim, which are only vehicles for the energy.
- What we speak of is always the emanation as we receive it, never God Himself.
- The many streams of wisdom, strength and wealth are one light seen through different filters, because humans compartmentalise.
- The Neshamah's idea of a "stream of good and a stream of bad" is rejected: from the source of good, no bad can come.
- "Oseh shalom uvore ra": God actively makes the good, and only allows the bad to exist, a step removed.

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